



THE NEVER-ENDING COVID STORY

COVID-19 IS BACK with a vengeance in several countries with a new sub-variant of Omicron named BA.2 or Stealth. China has locked down Shenzhen and some other cities; South Korea's daily Covid tally has crossed 600,000; Hong Kong, too, is recording a sharp rise in cases. Worrisomely, quite a few BA.2 variant cases have shown up in India, too, in Tamil Nadu. Time to beware.

—NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

**₹17
LAKH CRORE**
**AMOUNT PUMPED
IN BY THE CENTRAL BANK SINCE
THE COVID-19
PANDEMIC HIT
THE ECONOMY IN
MARCH 2020, SAID
RESERVE BANK
GOVERNOR SHAKTIKANTA DAS IN AN
INDUSTRY MEET
ORGANISED BY CII
ON MARCH 21**

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TV SETS TO GET DEARER

The rising prices of raw materials, higher freight charges, weakening Indian currency, and the Russia-Ukraine conflict's ripple effect will stress India's TV industry, with TV sets likely to get dearer by 7-10 per cent. Arjun Bajaaj, Director, Videotex International Group, says stocks and shipments will last 1-1.5 months, and the Shenzhen lockdown could worsen things.

—NIDHI SINGAL



SUVs ON TOP

The Indian auto market's dynamics are not what they used to be for eons. In 2015, the small SUV segment sold a little over 100,000 units while 620,000 premium hatchbacks were sold, according to Jato Dynamics. Cut to FY22. Till February, the industry managed to sell 540,000 hatchbacks and, for the first time, the number of entry-level SUVs was a little short of 600,000. It was also the first time any segment had overtaken the hatchback, India's largest segment so far. India is now truly an SUV market.

—PRERNA LIDHOO

Exports Milestone

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi announced recently that India has achieved the target of \$400 billion of exports for the first time. And now the government is targeting \$500 billion of exports in FY23, which experts believe is achievable. "India's exports touching \$400 billion is a miracle considering that they were stuck at \$275-330 billion from 2010-11 to 2020-21," says Ram Singh, Professor, Trade and Operation at Indian Institute of Foreign Trade. Ajai Sahai, Chairman of Federation of Indian Exports Organisations, opines that the Russia-Ukraine conflict would not impact us, as our exports to these countries is puny. But as Singh points out, imports growth is much higher than exports growth, which is widening the trade deficit.

—RAJAT MISHRA



BIG SCREEN GETS BIGGER

PVR INOX, the merged entity born from PVR Ltd's merger with second largest multiplex chain INOX Leisure, will be the largest film exhibition company in India with 1,546 screens in 109 cities, pushing Carnival with 450-plus screens to a distant second. The new entity will hold 40-45 per cent of India's multiplex revenues, bringing it into the crosshairs of the Competition Commission of India. But with revenues less than ₹1,000 crore, the CCI's threshold for exemption, it might just pass muster.

—VIDYA S.